Lapponica, in which he first aired his ideas about plant classifications.

Linnaeus further explored his idea for a new hierarchical system of plant classification in his 1735 book, *Systema Naturae*, and thereafter in arguably his greatest work, *Species Plantarum*, published in 1753, which covered 7,300 species. Previously, plants had been known by unwieldy names, such as *Plantago foliis ovato-lanceolatis pubescentibus, spica cylindrica, scapo tereti*. Linnaeus called this plant *Plantago media*, which was sufficient to identify it. As well as being concise, the Linnaean system describes relationships between species.

“In natural science, the principles of truth ought to be confirmed by observation.”

Carl Linnaeus

Later developments

Linnaeus constantly expanded *Systema Naturae*; its 10th edition (1758) became the starting point for modern animal classification. He argued that humans were members of the primate family. He also created taxonomical classifications for races of humans; now considered racist, which paved the way for colonial and eugenic thought. Much later, aided by Darwin’s theory of evolution by natural selection, biologists accepted that a classification should reflect the principle of common descent, which led to the methodology known as cladistics.